



Critical Conversations

TOPIC LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Upon successful completion of this topic, the student will be able to:
- 1. Recognize principles of consideration and candor that enable effective leadership.
 - 2. Recognize the impact of bias on decision making.
 - 3. Understand the linkage between a culture of awareness, individual character, and optimal organizational performance.
 - 4. Understand the need to resolve contentious issues expeditiously in the best interest of the organization, recognizing the existence of different perspectives.
 - 5. Identify specific techniques for improving performance within the workplace.

STUDENT PREPARATION

- Student Support Material
- 1. People Skills Handbook, Aanstadd-Corbett-Jourdan-Pearman, 2012
- Primary References
- 1. For Your Improvement, Korn Ferry, 2019, Eighth Edition
 - 2. Navy Necessary Conversations Guide, Version 3.0, April 2024 (draft)
 - 3. EDO School Note “Non-Attribution Policy”
- Additional References



Introduction

- This is an opportunity to practice engagement in challenging discussions
 - Facilitator's role
 - Provide relevant academic lessons
 - Guide an open dialogue

- Rules Of Engagement (ROE)
 - Involve everyone, teach back and be transparent
 - Non-attribution environment; bounded, but honest discussion



Assumptions

- What do “assumptions” have to do with critical thinking?
- Why is it important to validate your assumptions?
 - We all operate with a unique view of the world
 - Bad assumptions lead to bad decisions
- Real life examples...
 - Effects of bad assumptions



So What...

- Preformulated opinions can impair our ability to Get Real, Get Better (GRGB)
 - “Critical thinking requires a recognition of your biases.” – MaryAnn Watson, DAU
 - Critical thinking drives necessary rigor into our decision-making and problem-solving
 - Sometimes the barriers to optimal performance lie below the surface and our assumptions prevent us from seeing them
 - How does this affect innovation?



Emotional Intelligence (EQ)

- A vital set of skills that enable individuals to understand, manage, and utilize emotions effectively, both personally and interpersonally
 - Enhanced employee engagement by connecting with the team on an emotional level, understanding their needs, and motivating them effectively
 - Proficiency in recognizing how one's own emotions influence the team, allowing them to manage their responses and interactions in ways that promote a positive work environment

Emotionally intelligent leaders can navigate disputes with empathy and tact, fostering constructive resolutions and maintaining team cohesion



Preparing for a Difficult Conversation

- Recognize that different perceptions about the same reality can exist
 - We can all be right. Individual assumptions play a role. Embracing this understanding can lead to a path for resolution
- Create a convenient time and a “safe space” for the conversation
 - Be open and vulnerable; likely to be reciprocated
- Understand Human Motivation (3 Hs)
 - Heart, Head, Hand
- Understand Human Reaction (5 Fs)
 - Fight, Flight, Freeze, Fawn, Flop
- Apply Emotional Intelligence (EQ)
- Check your assumptions
 - Know yourself and your audience
 - Be aware of flawed logic

*It's ok to not know where to begin, **not starting is the only sure path to failure***



Flawed Logic

- Familiarize yourself with common assumptions and generalizations that influence false conclusions and distractions:
 - **Straw Man Fallacy**. Oversimplification or misrepresentation of someone's argument makes it easier to challenge or refute
 - **Causal Fallacy**. Assuming that one event caused another, without ample proof of the connection, accelerates decision-making
 - **Authority Fallacy**. Accepting a claim as true simply because an authority figure stated it simplifies decision-making
 - **Horn effect**. A single attribute can form a complete view of someone
 - **Halo effect**. A person who is well-liked can do no wrong
 - **Bandwagon effect**. The majority opinion should prevail
 - **Anchor effect**. The first piece of information received shapes the decision



Flawed Logic (cont'd)

- **Sunk cost effect**. Time and money invested justifies continuance
- **Attribution effect**. Judging oneself by intent, while others are judged by their actions, is perfectly valid
- **Over-attribution effect**. A person's individual behavior is determined by their abiding personal values and attitudes
- **Confirmation effect**. Evidence that supports an expectation overshadows contradictory evidence
- **Prototype effect**. Someone seems to fit the mold, therefore they are the perfect fit
- **Affinity effect**. The one that is most liked has instant advantage over the others
- Others?



Accomplishing a Difficult Conversation

- Set a neutral tone
 - Shared beliefs or values (common ground) could be a good starting point
- Build trust
 - Engage with dignity & respect, listen actively, assume positive intent
- Avoid blame; remember, we are a team. Learn from mistakes and move on
 - Start with “I” instead of “You” (e.g., “I didn’t receive...” vs “You didn’t deliver...” or “Help me understand...” vs “Why did you...”)
- Passion is good...until it impacts the ability to think and respond objectively
- Apply empathy; ask open-ended questions; more listening than talking
 - Embrace the power of “why”
- Talk about solutions or ways to avoid the unpleasant situation in the future
- Don’t presume a complete resolution from the initial discussion
- If conversation becomes confrontational, reframe it (defuse the situation)

Key components: Trust, Authenticity, Openness, Patience, and Courage



Candor With Senior Leadership

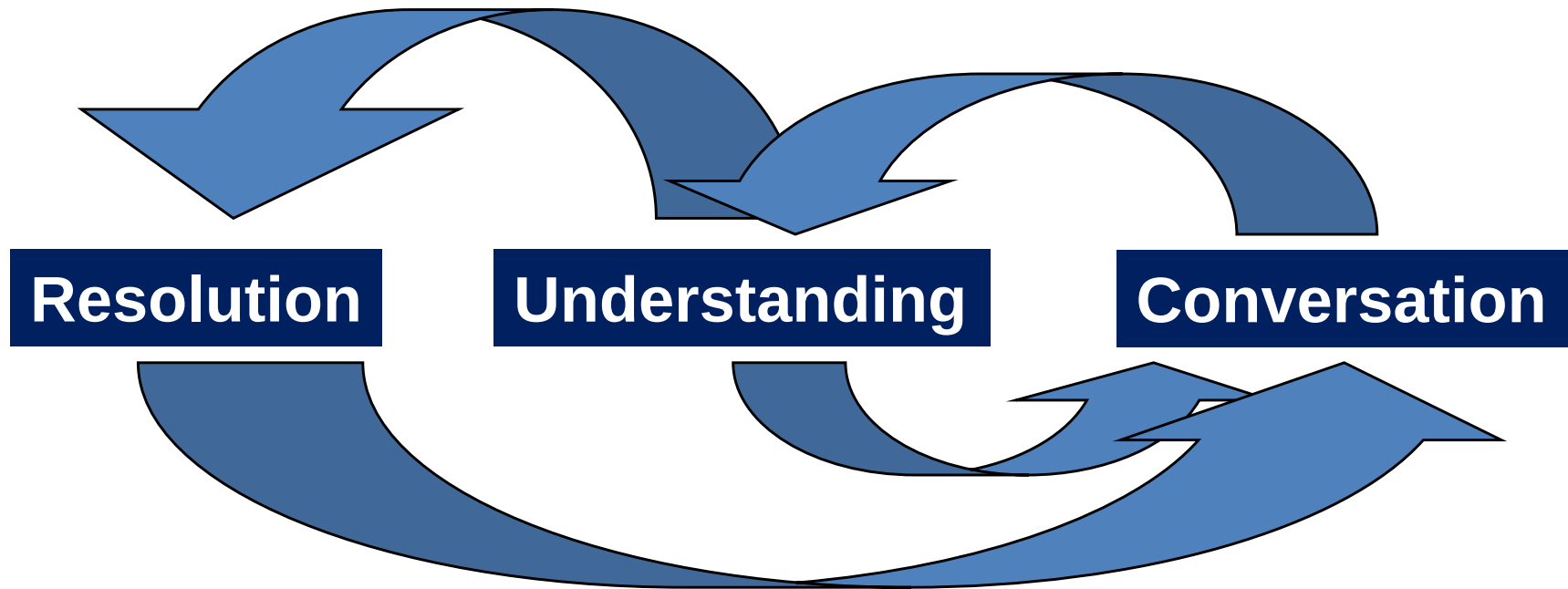
- Maintain humility
 - You may be the expert on the issues, engage with dignity & respect
- Are you well-versed in all relevant facts?
- Focus on solutions while providing clarity on root causes of prior issues
 - An elevator pitch may be useful here (see backup)
- Remember, we are on the same team and this is all about helping the team
- Direct > Ambiguous
- Anticipate concerns
- Don't presume a decision from the initial discussion

Key components: Trust, Authenticity, Openness, Patience, and Courage



Closing

- Your ability to properly address contentious situations is especially important at this stage of your career



Every conversation is a potential game-changer



Backup



Communicating for Buy-In

Concise Statement of the Issue + Resolution

Stop and ask yourself:
“Does this accurately
summarize the desired
outcome??”

#1 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

#2 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

#3 Strategic Message

Evidence to support

Goal is to get approval
for your proposed
action OR follow-up
meeting

Call to Action



Sound Bites

- “Respond to adversity; don’t react.” – Tony Dungy
- “Communicating is more than speaking; it involves your entire presence.” – NAVEDTRA 134
- “The more senior you become, the more you should listen.” – VADM Moore (ret)
- “What people believe prevails over the truth.” – Sophocles
- “You can’t make good decisions unless you have good information and can separate facts from opinions and speculation.” – Colin Powell
- “The initial reaction might be the most uninformed response.” – Tim Haney
- “Toughness and empathy are not incompatible.” – Robert Greene
- “Certainty is no substitute for clarity.” – Dr. Robert Radi
- “To be confident and not delusional is a real skill.” -- Katt Williams
- “Show up with humility.” – CAPT Jon Gandy
- “It’s not what you say, it’s what they hear.” – Red Auerbach
- “Turn up the gain on your receiver.” – RDML Mike Do
- “Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response.” – Viktor Frankl